

TEST PLAN VS TEST SCENARIOS

What they are, how they differ, and how they work in a real QA project.

Project Reference: OrangeHRM Web Application Testing

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What is a Test Plan?

- **Definition:** A formal document that defines the entire testing strategy for a project — what will be tested, how it will be tested, who will test it, and when.
- **When it is created:** Before any test case writing begins — during the Test Planning phase of STLC.
- **Detail Level:** High-level and strategic. It does not contain step-by-step test instructions.
- **Purpose:** To give the entire team a shared understanding of scope, approach, responsibilities, risks, and exit criteria before testing starts.
- **Owner:** Written by the QA Lead or Senior Tester. Reviewed and approved by the QA Manager.

In Simple Words

A Test Plan answers: **WHY** are we testing? **WHAT** will we test? **HOW** will we test it? **WHO** will test it? **WHEN** will it happen?

What a Test Plan Contains

Section	What It Covers
Project Overview	Application being tested, project goals, testing type
Scope	Modules included and excluded from testing
Test Objectives	What the testing aims to validate or prove
Test Strategy	Approach — black-box, risk-based, manual, automated
Test Environment	OS, browsers, tools, and infrastructure required
Entry & Exit Criteria	Conditions to start testing and to declare it complete
Roles & Responsibilities	Who does what — tester, QA lead, developer
Risk Assessment	What can go wrong and how to mitigate it
Test Schedule	Timeline and milestones for each testing phase
Deliverables	Documents to be produced — test cases, defect reports, TSR

OrangeHRM — Test Plan Example

Here is how the Test Plan was defined for the OrangeHRM project:

Test Plan Element	OrangeHRM Definition
Project	OrangeHRM Web Application (opensource-demo.orangehrmlive.com)
Testing Type	Manual Black-Box Testing
Modules In-Scope	Login, Search, My Info, Admin
Modules Out-Scope	Leave, Time, Recruitment, Performance, Reports
Test Approach	Risk-based; Equivalence Partitioning + Boundary Value Analysis
Environment	Windows 10/11 Chrome, Edge, Firefox Jira + Excel
Entry Criteria	Test plan approved + demo environment accessible
Exit Criteria	90%+ execution, all Critical/High defects retested, TSR signed
Schedule	May 01–30, 2026 (Requirement → Planning → Writing → Execution → Closure)
Tester	Piyush Bhagchandani

What are Test Scenarios?

- **Definition:** High-level descriptions of what needs to be tested for a specific feature or module. They focus on the functionality or user workflow — not the step-by-step instructions.
- **When they are created:** After the Test Plan is approved — before test cases are written.
- **Detail Level:** Less detailed than test cases. Each scenario is typically one sentence describing a situation to be validated.
- **Purpose:** To ensure complete functional coverage of the application and to identify all possible areas that need testing.
- **Owner:** Written by the Tester based on requirements and the approved Test Plan.

In Simple Words

A Test Scenario answers: **WHAT** situation or functionality needs to be tested? It does NOT describe how to test it.

OrangeHRM — Test Scenario Examples

These are real test scenarios written for the OrangeHRM project:

Scenario ID	Module	Test Scenario
TS-001	Login	Test that a user can log in with valid credentials.
TS-002	Login	Test that the system rejects login with a blank username.
TS-003	Login	Test that the login page is protected against SQL injection.
TS-004	Login	Test that the session expires after a period of inactivity.
TS-005	Search	Test that searching a valid module name returns relevant results.
TS-006	Search	Test that searching with special characters does not cause errors.
TS-007	My Info	Test that the First Name field rejects numeric input.
TS-008	My Info	Test that a future date cannot be entered in Date of Birth.
TS-009	My Info	Test that the Employee ID field is not editable by the user.
TS-010	Admin	Test that an Admin can create a new system user.
TS-011	Admin	Test that a partial username search returns matching results.
TS-012	Admin	Test that an ESS user cannot access the Admin panel.

Notice: each scenario is one clear sentence — no steps, no test data, no expected results. Those details come later in the Test Case.

Test Plan vs Test Scenarios — Key Differences

Aspect	Test Plan	Test Scenarios
What it is	Strategy document for the whole project	List of situations to be tested per module
When created	Start of the project — before writing begins	After Test Plan is approved
Detail level	High-level — scope, approach, schedule	Mid-level — one sentence per scenario
Focus	WHY, WHAT, HOW, WHO, WHEN (overall)	WHAT needs to be tested (per feature)
Contains	Scope, strategy, risks, schedule, criteria	IDs, module names, scenario descriptions
Written by	QA Lead / Senior Tester	Tester
Used for	Project planning and stakeholder alignment	Coverage mapping before test case writing
Example	'Test the Login module using black-box manual testing'	'Test that login is rejected for blank username'

Where They Fit in STLC

STLC Phase	Activity	Output
1. Requirement Analysis	Understand what the application does	Requirement notes, feature list
2. Test Planning	Define scope, strategy, risk, schedule	■ TEST PLAN
3. Test Scenario Design	Identify all situations to be tested	■ TEST SCENARIOS
4. Test Case Writing	Write step-by-step instructions per scenario	Test Cases (Excel/Jira)
5. Test Execution	Execute test cases against the application	Execution results, defect reports
6. Test Closure	Summarise results, close defects, sign off	Test Summary Report (TSR)

OrangeHRM Project Flow

- **May 01–04:** Requirement Analysis — understood OrangeHRM modules and features.
- **May 05–07:** Test Planning — wrote and approved the Test Plan.
- **May 08:** Test Scenario Design — identified scenarios per module before writing test cases.
- **May 08–14:** Test Case Writing — wrote 71 test cases based on the scenarios.
- **May 15–24:** Test Execution — ran all 71 test cases; logged 13 defects in Jira.
- **May 25–28:** Test Closure — produced Test Summary Report.

Summary

- **Test Plan** is the strategic document created at the start. It defines the full scope, approach, team, tools, schedule, and quality criteria for the entire project.
- **Test Scenarios** are created after the plan is approved. Each one is a single high-level statement describing a situation that needs to be validated — not how to test it.
- **Test Cases** come after scenarios. Each scenario produces one or more test cases with step-by-step instructions, test data, and expected results.

Plan → Scenarios → Test Cases → Execute → Report